

COLD START

A preflight check for coding agents.

Paste a public GitHub repo URL. Get back a grounded AGENTS.md, a landmine report where every finding cites a file, and three next-task prompts you can paste straight into Codex.



cold-start

`github.com/acme/api`

- repo map
- 11 landmines
- AGENTS.md
- 3 Codex prompts

scanned 48 of 60 files

1 model call

Nishad Dhakephalkar

Codex Build House, Pune · 5-6 September 2026

An agent's first ten minutes are guesswork

1 It guesses the build command
and runs the one the README had two refactors ago.

2 It guesses which directories matter
and reads the generated ones.

3 It guesses what is already half-built
and starts it again.

4 It never learns what broke last time
because nobody wrote it down.

AGENTS.md, as it usually exists

```
# AGENTS.md
```

```
Run `npm start` to start.
```

```
TODO: fill this in
```

```
- last edited 8 months ago,  
  by whoever set the repo up,  
  never opened since.
```

Written by hand, once. Never updated. Trusted anyway.

WHAT IT DOES

One URL in. Four things out.

1 Repo map

Detected stack, entrypoints, top-level directory roles, and the real dev / build / test / lint commands — each shown with the file it came from.

2 Landmine report

The things that make an agent fail. Four deterministic checks, every finding carrying a file path and a line.

3 A generated AGENTS.md

Built from what is actually in the repo. Copy it or download it straight into the project you scanned.

4 Three Codex prompts

One model call turns the findings into three half-hour tasks, each written as a complete Goal / Context / Constraints / Done-when prompt.

About ten seconds. No clone, no install, no login.

Four checks. Every finding cites a file.

● **missing-env**

Environment variables read in source with no `.env.example` and no README entry.

```
lib/db.ts:14  process.env.DATABASE_URL
```

● **command-drift**

README commands that are not declared scripts or Makefile targets — and scripts the README never mentions.

```
README.md:22  npm run serve → not a script
```

● **setup-gaps**

No lockfile, no test command, no CI workflow, no README.

```
.github/  no workflow file found
```

● **unfinished**

TODO / FIXME / HACK markers, skipped tests and merge-conflict markers, aggregated per file.

```
api/routes.py  7 markers, 2 skipped tests
```

Evidence is the point. If a claim cannot be cited, it is not reported.

WHY YOU CAN TRUST IT

The model is the smallest part of it

1

call

Exactly one model call per scan

lib/llm.ts is the only file in the repository that talks to OpenAI. Every other layer is a pure function with no I/O.

0

unsourced claims

Every finding carries evidence

A path, and a line or a snippet. Severity is fixed in code, per check — never decided by a model.

100

% still renders

It degrades, it does not break

If the key is missing, the call fails, or it times out at twenty seconds, the map, the findings and the AGENTS.md all still render.

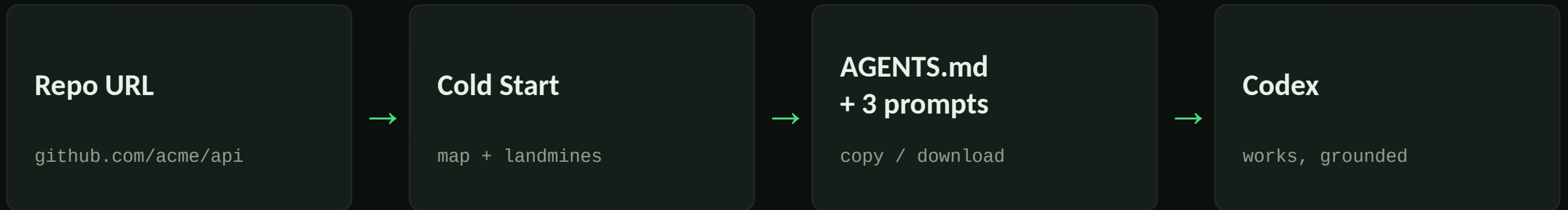
%

It reports its own coverage.

“scanned 48 of 60 files” — so you know exactly how much of the repository the findings rest on, instead of trusting a silent sample.

THE POINT

Its output is Codex's input



A generated prompt, verbatim

Goal: Add a `.env.example` covering the four variables read in `src/`.
Context: `lib/db.ts:14` and `lib/mail.ts:9` read `DATABASE_URL`, `SMTP_URL`,
`SMTP_USER` and `SMTP_PASS`. No `.env.example` exists and the `README`
does not mention them.
Constraints: No new dependencies. Do not commit real values.
Done when: `.env.example` lists all four keys with empty values and the
`README`'s setup section references it.

3

prompts per scan,
about thirty minutes
of work each

Paste it into Codex. It runs.

HOW IT IS BUILT

One screen, one endpoint, pure functions

app/page.tsx

the single screen: input, loading, report

app/api/scan/route.ts

POST { url } → ScanResult. The only orchestration.

lib/github.ts

all GitHub fetching. Nothing else touches the network.

lib/checks/*.ts

one pure function per check. No I/O.

lib/map.ts

repo map derivation. Pure.

lib/agentsmd.ts

ScanResult → AGENTS.md. Pure.

lib/llm.ts

the single OpenAI call. The only one.

types.ts

ScanResult and every sub-type. One source of truth.

Stack

Next.js (App Router) · TypeScript · Tailwind · Vercel

No database. No auth. No queue. Zero runtime dependencies beyond React.

Built with Codex

Written over two days at the Build House, in three scoped prompts, against an AGENTS.md that Cold Start itself would now generate.

Cold Start's first real finding was about itself: it read two environment variables and shipped no .env.example.

Try it on a repo you have not opened in months.

Live

cold-start-kappa.vercel.app

Source

github.com/Ndhakeph/cold-start

10s

from a URL to an
AGENTS.md you can
actually commit

Cold Start

Nishad Dhakephalkar · Codex Build House, Pune · 5-6 September 2026